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Original Page: 140**Culture (OWC):** [Tonga \(FQ12\)](#)**Region:** Africa**Sub Region:** Southern Africa**Field Date:** 1946-1947, 1948, 1950**Coverage Date:** 1945-1951**Place Coverage**

northeast-central Southern province, Zambia

Section Title(S)CHAPTER VI HUSBAND AND WIFE • Comradeship and Etiquette in Marriage

When asked about instances in the past, informants said that they could remember seeing old women who went about carrying an axe, a tool so identified with men that it is a common masculine symbol, but that these women otherwise dressed as women and worked as women. During *masabe* dancing, which may be performed either as a curing ritual or as pure entertainment, either men or women may dress as members of the opposite sex. Women *masabe* leaders carry an axe. Occasionally women dress up as men on other occasions as a joke to entertain the hamlet on a dull evening. For the rest, they are content to be women, and they take their formal subordination within the household as a matter of course and with a grain of salt.

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Comradeship and Etiquette in Marriage

In discussing marriage, women stress the companionship to be found within it. One, in describing her refusal to marry a polygynist, said, 'It was because I wanted a husband of my own with whom I could walk always!' Others commented, 'If you were married, you would sit here talking to your husband about what had happened during the day. Wouldn't that be pleasant?' A woman living in a village with many of her relatives said, 'It is good to have children. Now when my husband is away on a visit, I am not lonely.' Men stress this note less, but some have told me, 'Your wife is the best friend you have. Once you are married, she becomes your mother. She feeds you and looks after you when you are ill. She is your mother indeed.' This sentiment was publicly stated by a court official during the hearing of Case VIII (see below) as the ideal governing marriage.

Companionship does in fact enter into marriage much more than it does in many African societies. One frequently finds husband and wife sitting together, talking quietly over family affairs or the day's happenings. Each man has his favourite spot in front ■ [140-A]

(a) Women's work (Nampeyo)



(b) Men and women dance together at a beer drink (Mujika) PLATE IV

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141 of his hut or huts where he usually can be found. There he sits or reclines, carries on some craft, or minds the baby, while his wife works near by or relaxes on the verandah. Occasionally the whole family will eat together from one set of dishes, although the usual custom is for men and women to eat separately. The whole pattern of comradeship is furthered by the desire of men to build their own homesteads, for only those who live in the same homestead habitually eat together. Thus, often, there are no men about for the husband to join unless he walks a few yards to another homestead, and there he becomes a visitor. He prefers to stay at home with his wife.

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